had opened a direct channel with Brezhnev on Afghanistan).[23] Simultaneously, India's ambassador to Afghanistan, Jaskaran Teja, and special envoy (and then also an assistant secretary in the MEA) S. K. Singh informed the new Afghan leadership that India's main interest was to maintain people-to-people relations with Afghanistan and to continue supporting Afghanistan in sectors such as health, education, and hydel-power.[24] New Delhi had no desire to interfere in domestic Afghan affairs, and would 'deal with whichever government was de facto in power'.[25] Despite Gandhi's sympathy with the Afghan revolution of 1978, India 'was opposed to violence' and to 'Soviet military intervention in Afghanistan'.[26] New Delhi did not indulge in diplomatic polemics of an anti-Soviet nature, but Moscow was aware of India's 'serious reservations' regarding the implications of the Soviet military. And surely, India was equally wary of Afghanistan being dominated by radical Islamists and/or by the US.

Thirdly, Gandhi launched a diplomatic initiative with Pakistan and the West (US and UK primarily) to bridge differences. The only country missing in this diplomatic exercise was China, with whom both India and the USSR's relations were frosty.[27] To begin with, India abstained (along with sixteen other countries) from voting on the UNGA Resolution ES-6/2 against Soviet actions in January 1980, though the resolution passed with a resounding majority of 104 against 18.[28] Having shocked the world after her u-turn, Gandhi hoped that this abstention would signal to the West and Islamabad that India was not necessarily siding with the Soviets. In fact, some in India genuinely hoped that the Soviet intervention would force Pakistan to 'bury the hatchet' on Kashmir and shape a regional South Asian solution to the problem with Indian support.[29] Soon afterwards in February 1980, Swaran Singh was dispatched to Islamabad for initiating a dialogue as special envoy, and to inform Pakistani military chief and President, Zia-ul-Haq, that the latter 'could remove as many divisions as he wished from the Indian border without fear of any advantage being taken by India', and to suggest talks on reduction of force levels.[30] Gandhi knew that Russia had violated the strategic 'buffer', as the British Raj imagined Afghanistan to be, and Pakistan would surely retaliate. As a senior Indian journalist put it:

> Many of us [Indians] have also bought lock, stock, and barrel, the 19th century British view that the sub-continent's natural frontier was the Hindu Kush, that it would be dangerous for India if Soviet